

In the second section of *Human Nature and Conduct*, John Dewey concludes that, “Habit means special sensitiveness or accessibility to certain classes of stimuli, standing predilections and aversions”, and to obtain or alter a habit, one needs to do more than just “bare recurrence of specific acts”. He ends by stating that habit “means will” (68) – but what does this mean exactly? First, an attempt will be made at defining the concept of will; then it will be shown how habits are formed through one’s will, whether or not influenced by some external variable(s), and not simply through the process of repetition, alone.

To help us understand what *will* means, let us consider the following example. An individual gets hungry sitting in a chair. This goes on for some time, until finally, the individual gets up, grants their stomach with food, and in return is given silence. The moment the individual switches both mentally and physically from sitting to standing up in the pursuit of food – this is due to the individual being *willing* to do these things. And even yet, someone could argue that the individual was just as much *willing* to not eat as they sat there listening to how hungry they had become. And this too seems correct. So then, our actions depend, to a large degree, on our will. Whether or not the person in our example above ate, the choice – the action – to move or to continue sitting, stems from what the person wills – what they want to do. And as Dewey states, the “formation of ideas as well as their execution depends upon habit.” (52) So, to make it more clear, Dewey would argue that it is because of habit that the person became willing to eat something, and that “[habits] form our effective desires...they rule our thoughts, determining which shall appear and be strong”. (45) So, even before the person knew they were hungry, a habit had been set in motion – that of having one’s own bodily organs working together in ways that led to the individual’s brain being aware of their body’s hunger. What we see on the surface is someone making a habit out of eating when hungry, yet what is really happening is the

cooperation of many pre-existing habits that help in the forming of a new one, i.e., eating when hungry. As dewey exhausts, “reason [action] pure of all influence from prior habit is a fiction.”

(53)

So as of now, it seems that will leads to action, but that habit sets forth the thoughts and other motivators to call into question our will, which then leads to said actions. In the words of Dewey, the “act must come before the thought, and a habit before the ability to evoke the thought at will.” (52) It is only when we stop to think of why we perform certain acts that it becomes clear how we take for granted the habits that are truly us in essence, giving birth to the thoughts that we then act upon. Since it has been shown that habit gives rise to action, and that it is after this action is put through the process of repetition that one can start to say they *know something* or can *do something*, we should agree with Dewey in that “...we must protest against the tendency in psychological literature to limit [habits’] meaning to [strictly] repetition.” (68) For “[habits] require order, discipline, and manifest technique.”(33) Repetition then seems to be just another function of habit. It’s not that a habit is formed from repetition, but instead it is from habit that repetition is even possible. Therefore, “repetition is in no sense the essence of habit.”

(68)

It seems rather odd to consider the idea that first, habits aren’t products of repetition like we commonly think, and second, that habits lead to our confrontation with our will, leading to a certain action that if repeated over time, may tempt one in saying, “Person A has developed a habit of doing X”. But it would be more appropriate to say something closer to the following: “Due to habit, person A willed into existence an action, and so many times repeated it, so that a new habit has formed for person A. To say that habit can be summed up as simply repetition, is

to say that an action can be performed without any presence of will from the individual performing it, or from any other external variable.